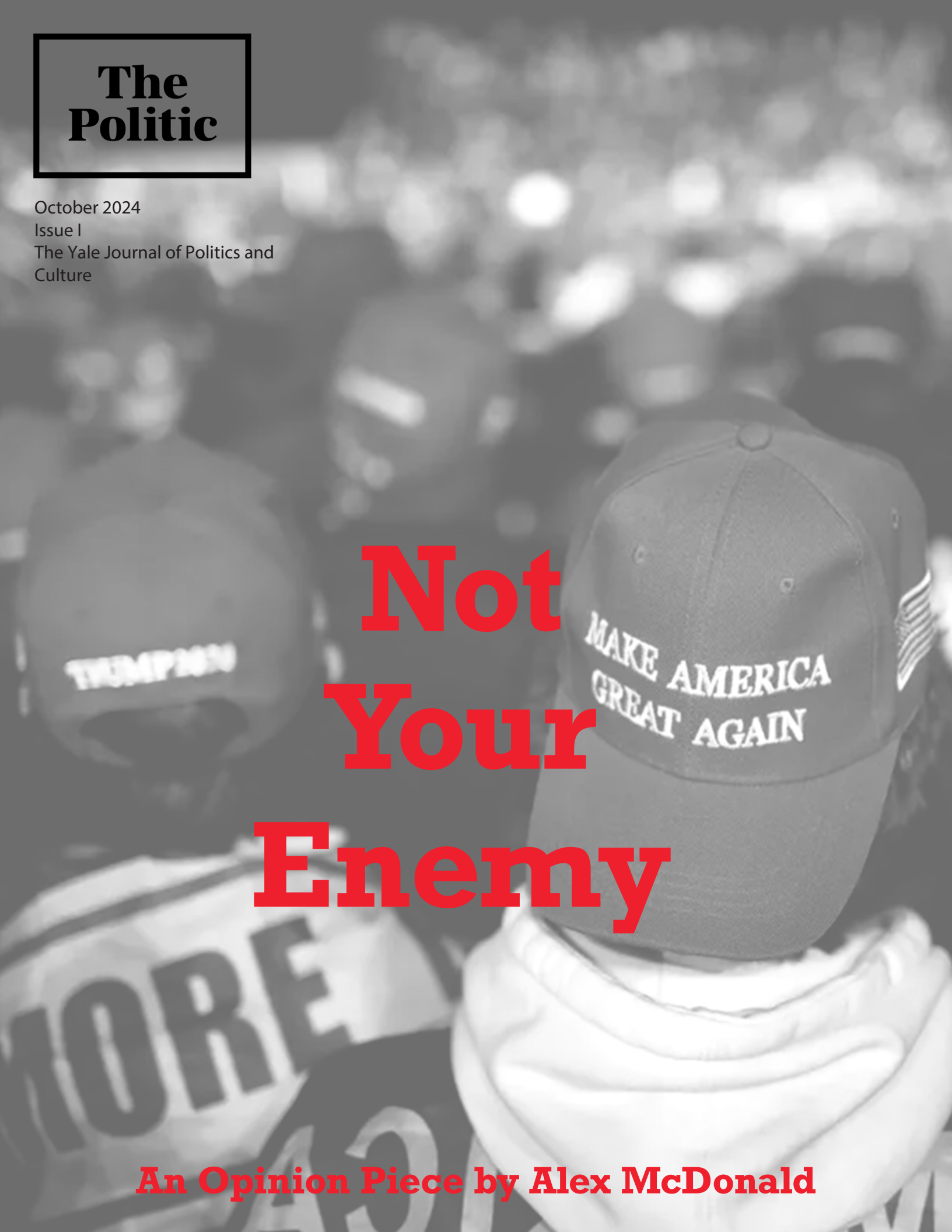
The Politic

October 2024
Issue I
The Yale Journal of Politics and Culture



Not Your Enemy

An Opinion Piece by Alex McDonald

mast-he-ad

MANAGING BOARD

Editors-in-Chief
Theo Sotoodehnia
Samantha Moon

Online Managing Editors
Phoenix Boggs
Grey Battle

Print Managing Editors
Alexia Dochnal
Sovy Pham

Publisher
Owen Haywood

Multi-media Managing Editor
Eliza Daunt

EDITORIAL BOARD

Associate Editors
Nicole Manning
Vittal Sivakumar
Mira Dubler-Furman
Rory Schoenberger
Nicole Chen
Adnan Bseisu
Alex McDonald
Natalie Miller
Rebecca Wasserman
Sarah Jacobs

Staff Writers
Adnan Bseisu
Nicole Chen
Nicole Manning
Natalie Miller
Alex McDonald

OPERATIONS BOARD

Technology Director
Dylan Bober

Business Team
Alex McDonald

Communications Director
Mira Dubler-Furman

Business Director
Lauren Kim

CREATIVE TEAM

Creative Director
Ainslee Garcia

Design Editors
Katie Shin
Alexa Druyanoff
Ajay Singreddy
Carter Cashen

BOARD OF ADVISERS

John Lewis Gaddis
Robert A. Lovett Professor of Military and Naval History, Yale University

Ian Shapiro
Henry R. Luce Director of the MacMillan Center for International and Area Studies at Yale

Mike Pearson
Features Editor, Toledo Blade

Gideon Rose
Former Editor-in-Chief of Foreign Affairs

John Stoehr
Editor and Publisher, The Editorial Board

Cover Photos Credit: Scott Olsen/Getty Images

LETTER FROM THE EDITORS

Dear Readers,

Welcome to the first issue of the 2024-2025 school year! We, The Politic's Managing Board, are beyond excited to share it with you. This issue is split into four sections: features, opinion, interviews, and photo-essays, and focuses on the elections happening across our country this November, from the presidential race to state-level ballot measures.

This issue kicks off with three feature pieces, beginning with "Midwestern Roots, National Ambitions" by Logan Day-Richter, which examines Tim Walz and the politics behind his Vice Presidential nomination. It continues with "When Colleges Close" by Aubrie Williams, an exploration of the impact the loss of an institution of higher learning has on the community around it. Rounding out the features section, Emi Glass dives into the politics of an anti-gerrymandering ballot initiative in Ohio in her piece "Power to the People."

Our cover story, "Not Your Enemy," is an opinion piece by Alex McDonald examining polarization and the way many on the political left demonize Republicans and others who plan to vote for former President Donald Trump. In putting an opinion piece on the cover, we have chosen to return to The Politic's roots—our magazine was founded in 1947 as a venue for students' views to shine. This fall, with a consequential election approaching, we wanted to spotlight the diversity of perspectives on campus along with our usual features and investigative pieces.

The issue then moves on to "From Activism to Extremism," an interview conducted by Yegor Rubinov with Anna Biryukova, an exiled Russian activist and close aide to the late Russian opposition leader Alexei Navalny.

The issue concludes with two photo essays. In her work "Navigating Tradition and Transition," Hanna Klingbeil examines the politics, past, and future of the street-food scene on New Haven's Long Wharf. Then, in "Yard Wars," Rory Schoenberger examines dueling campaign signs in Woodbridge, Connecticut.

Our online-only content this issue is also election-focused, and includes a series of short opinion pieces by Yale students grappling with issues this election cycle which matter deeply to the states they are from but aren't getting the coverage they merit.

This issue was put together with the help of our wonderful design team, and we would like to extend a special thank you to all of them. Our Managing Board is so excited to be back for the 2024-25 school year. We hope you enjoy this issue as much as we enjoyed putting it together!

All the best,
The 2024-2025 Politic Managing Board

contents

LOGAN DAY-RICHTER
contributing writer
2
MIDWESTERN ROOTS, NATIONAL AMBITIONS
Tim Walz's Influence on the 2024 Election

AUBRIE WILLIAMS
contributing writer
6
WHEN COLLEGES CLOSE
The Devastating Effects of Liberal Arts College Shutdowns

EMI GLASS
contributing writer
10
POWER TO THE PEOPLE
How Ohio's Issue 1 Seeks to Reform the Redistricting Process

ALEX MCDONALD
opinion writer
16
NOT YOUR ENEMY
In Defense of Republicans Voting for Trump

YEGOR RUBANOV
contributing writer
22
FROM ACTIVISM TO EXTREMISM
Anna Biryukova's Fight Against Corruption and Authoritarianism

HANNA KLINGBEIL
contributing writer
28
NAVIGATING TRADITION AND TRANSITION
Exploring Food Trucks at the New Haven Long Wharf

RORY SCHOENBERGER
associate editor
32
YARD WARS
Woodbridge's Campaign Sign Showdown

*This magazine is published by Yale College students, and Yale University is not responsible for its contents. The opinions expressed by the contributors to *The Politic* do not necessarily reflect those of its staff or advertisers.



Tim Walz's influence on the 2024 election

To be quite honest, he never would have crossed my mind

TIONS

by Logan Day-Richter

"To be quite honest, he never would have crossed my mind," said Greg Jones. Jones, who has taught English in the Duluth public school system for 27 years, was surprised by Vice President Kamala Harris' selection of Minnesota Governor Tim Walz as her running mate in the 2024 presidential race.

"I thought he would never get chosen. He's way too nice of a guy. People talk about the Midwest as being flyover states and say that we don't really matter all that much—we're not particularly unique—so I thought that the people who are decision-makers would also think that," said Jones

The Harris campaign's selection of Walz came as a shock to many Democrats and Republicans alike. Historically, presidential candidates use their vice presidential pick as a means of appealing to a demographic of voters that the candidate wishes to court. Though it is difficult to demonstrate direct causality, some partially attribute former President Donald Trump's popularity among white evangelical voters to his vice presidential choice of Mike Pence, a devout evangelical, who during the 2016 campaign repeatedly called himself, "a Christian, a conservative and a Republican, in that order." Similar to Pence's embodiment of the evangelical vote in 2016, Walz may appeal to Midwestern voters. The Midwest is bound to play a significant role in this election, given that Michigan and Wisconsin are imperative states for a Harris victory in November.

"Every decision is consequential; most effects are probably incredibly tiny, but even tiny effects like a couple hundred or a couple thousand votes in a close presidential election are going to be significant," said Joshua Kalla, a Yale University professor of political science and data science who studies political persuasion, as well as voter and campaign decision making.

Aside from Walz, two other running mate candidates were shortlisted for this position. The first candidate was Pennsylvania Governor Josh Shapiro, who was Pennsylvania's attorney general from 2017 to 2023 and was subsequently elected Pennsylvania Governor in 2022 by a margin of nearly 15 percentage points. The other contender was Senator Mark Kelly (D-AZ), a former United States Navy captain and astronaut who flipped a senate seat by defeating the incumbent Republican, Senator Martha McSally, in the 2020 Arizona special senate election.

Many commentators expected Shapiro to be the frontrunner as Harris's running mate due to his status as a popular politician from a battleground state that holds the potential to decide the presidential race by a razor-thin vote margin. In the wake of the Harris campaign's selection of Walz, some criticized the Harris campaign for ignoring the opportunity to garner a "home state advantage" in Pennsylvania. Such criticism insinuates that the edge Shapiro may have offered in Pennsylvania, a critical swing state, made him a more politically strategic pick than Walz, whose home state of Minnesota is far less likely to be competitive in this election.

Kalla summarized this sentiment among pundits: "If Pennsylvania ends up being the tipping-point state and if Harris loses Pennsylvania by 5000 votes, are there going to be 1000 op-ed's saying Harris should have picked Josh Shapiro? Yes."

During his time as the governor of Minnesota, Walz has championed ample progressive legislation while appealing to his Midwestern, rural, middle-class roots. For example, Walz has made it clear that education is one of his top priorities. "The way the state funds education is important to me," said Jones. "We live in a state where we have a governor who is an educator and so he also pays a lot of attention to choices that are made on the state level that would impact classrooms." Among the most

> **Every decision is consequential**

notable legislation Walz signed into law as governor was an education package that, among other initiatives, provides free breakfasts and lunches for all students in Minnesota public schools.

For decades, Democrats have been working hard to shake the label of being a party dominated by out-of-touch politicians and elites, removed from the needs of many voters. Walz appears to be countering this reputation. Jones reported that Walz's consideration of teachers is frequently visible on the campaign trail: "I liked him from the beginning when he first started running for governor. He went all over the state to reach out to voters and came up to teachers who came out to hear what he had to say, and he's a good listener."

Outside of Walz's flagship education package, other bills he signed into law as Minnesota governor include voting re-enfranchisement of 50,000 former felons, statewide legislation guaranteeing access to abortion in the wake of the Supreme Court's 2022 Dobbs decision, and the adoption of stricter background checks for gun sales. While the Trump campaign criticized Walz as "dangerously liberal" upon his selection as Harris's running mate, Walz has some characteristics that may appeal to wider interests beyond progressives alone, such as being a gun owner and an Army veteran. On a larger, national scale, Jones finds Walz to be a compelling figure for the future of America on a national stage, representing a Midwestern identity: "I appreciate his values."

Aside from Jones, other voters find the choice of Walz on the Harris ticket to be compelling for broader reasons. Zach Pan '27, Treasurer of Yale College Democrats, along with many other supporters of the Harris campaign are enthusiastic about the narrative that Walz brings to national politics in the Democratic Party. "He has a no-nonsense, common sense style of approaching governing that's needed in our politics," said Pan.

Despite disagreement on whether Walz will be of much consequence for the persuasion of voters, Pan expressed confidence: "When you elect a leader, the story matters. Walz coached a high school football team in a small town. And you combine that with a legacy of policy successes as Minnesota Governor, and that's a pretty potent formula for winning votes: not only being able to point to a record, but also being able to be someone who's likable, genuine and kind."

"Both candidates did a great job in picking someone that would back them 100 percent," said Hilda Barragan-Reyes '26, chairman of the Yale Tory Party, a conservative-leaning Yale Political Union debate society. Barragan-Reyes agreed to speak to The Politic under the condition that it was noted that her views do not necessarily reflect those of the Yale Tory Party as a whole.

Assessments of the vice presidential candidates vary among conservatives. Barragan-Reyes spoke highly of the American success story that JD Vance YLS '13 brings to the Trump ticket and suggested that it may be compelling to some voters: "I'm a huge fan of Hillbilly Elegy…[Vance] is the classic American example of pulling yourself up by the bootstraps."

Vance's 2016 memoir, Hillbilly Elegy, chronicles his experience growing up in Appalachia, confronted with familial and systemic challenges, such as alcoholism, abuse, and poverty. Since Vance graduated from Yale Law School in 2013 and subsequently published his bestselling memoir, Hillbilly Elegy has provided a story of social mobility in the face of hardship, and has served as a cornerstone of Vance's depiction of himself on the campaign trail, both as a Senator and vice presidential candidate.

Despite the compelling individualist and American Dream narrative that some voters believe Vance provides, Barragan-Reyes is skeptical as to whether he will prove to be an asset for the Trump campaign. She suggested that a more moderate or less abrasive figure could have better served the Trump campaign. "Trump is already a controversial figure. JD Vance has said some equally off-putting things on social media and in public…I wouldn't want to put two explosive people together," said Barragan-Reyes. While Barragan-Reyes indicated that Vance may be too callous and inflammatory for the Trump campaign, she doesn't necessarily see Walz presenting the same danger to the Harris campaign. She insinuated that in addition to his moderating character influence, Walz may have a centrist appeal that Vance does not possess: "I don't see Walz as being an incredibly left-leaning candidate."

Barragan-Reyes continued, "[Vance] says things that are completely out of whack and makes voting for Trump look more ridiculous. It's hard for people now, even amongst conservatives, to say with a straight face, 'I'm voting for Donald Trump,' and I think JD Vance has been a huge part of that."

Vance has been the subject of bipartisan criticism for changing his position on Trump; despite his current position of loyalty as Trump's running mate, Vance has sharply attacked Trump in the past. In a 2016 private message to a colleague, Vance wrote "I go back and forth between thinking Trump is a cynical asshole like Nixon who wouldn't be that bad (and might even prove useful) or that he's America's Hitler."

"The Trump campaign really lost out on their VP pick," said Barragan-Reyes. "Tim Walz comes off as the fun-loving dad. And again, it's all about the vibes," she added, suggesting that Walz would prove to be useful for the Harris campaign in

> **He has a no-nonsense, common sense style of approaching governing that's needed in our politics**

“I’m happy that the rest of the country is getting to know him”

People just don't really care about the vice president

an election where character assessments of candidates may shape its outcome. Barragan-Reyes said, “I think Tim Walz is going to be huge.”

The electorate’s varying views of the vice presidential candidates raise the question: will the vice presidential candidates play a significant role in influencing the presidential race?

Though many Democrats like Pan are optimistic about what a Harris-Walz ticket will mean for undecided voters, some analysts believe Walz might not be a deciding force for the election. A September 5, 2024 USA Today and Suffolk University poll of likely voters found a 48% favorability rating for Walz, compared to a 37% favorability rating for Vance. Similarly, the poll found that Walz had a 36% unfavorability rating, compared to 49% for Vance. The poll also found that both candidates are approximately equally well-known.

However, the share of respondents who did not express an opinion on the vice presidential candidates is significantly higher than for the top of the tickets. Kalla explained what these results may imply about the influence the vice presidential candidates might have on the race: “The type of people who have an opinion about JD Vance or Tim Walz are the type of people who follow the news and the presidential race pretty closely. They already have a lot of opinions. They are quite partisan and quite set in their ways. Swing undecided voters: they’re the ones who don’t have an opinion of JD Vance or Tim Walz.”

It is true that many decided voters described Walz to be a compelling, warm, likable politician, who is particularly appealing to working class Midwestern Americans. However, it is unclear whether Walz will have the same effect on the undecided portion of the electorate whose votes will ultimately be decisive in this election.

“There’s a reason why HBO made the show Veep, right?” quipped Kalla. “People just don’t really care about the vice president.” In a political climate dominated by daily news cycles, short-term political battles, and partisanship, the nuances of the vice presidential race can appear far-removed from the lives of voters who will ultimately decide this election.

Moreover, Kalla suggested that local political races may be of far more consequence for many voters: “If you have limited time to be worried about politics, to learn about politics, you should be focusing on your school board, you should be focusing on your mayor, you should be focusing on your member of Congress.”

Ultimately, it may be impossible to conclusively determine whether the vice presidential candidates will prove to be consequential for the outcome of the election, though it appears unlikely. The presidency and the occupant of the second-highest executive office in the United States will be in the hands of the voters on November 5th.

As for one of those voters specifically, “I would like [Minnesota] to keep Walz, personally,” Jones said endearingly of the governor of his home state, “But I’m happy that the rest of the country is getting to know him.”

When you elect a leader, the story matters



WHEN COLLEGE

THE DEVASTATING EFFECTS OF LIBERAL ARTS COLLEGE SHUTDOWNS
THE DEVASTATING EFFECTS OF LIBERAL ARTS COLLEGE SHUTDOWNS
THE DEVASTATING EFFECTS OF LIBERAL ARTS COLLEGE SHUTDOWNS
THE DEVASTATING EFFECTS OF LIBERAL ARTS COLLEGE SHUTDOWNS
THE DEVASTATING EFFECTS OF LIBERAL ARTS COLLEGE SHUTDOWNS
THE DEVASTATING EFFECTS OF LIBERAL ARTS COLLEGE SHUTDOWNS
THE DEVASTATING EFFECTS OF LIBERAL ARTS COLLEGE SHUTDOWNS
THE DEVASTATING EFFECTS OF LIBERAL ARTS COLLEGE SHUTDOWNS
THE DEVASTATING EFFECTS OF LIBERAL ARTS COLLEGE SHUTDOWNS
THE DEVASTATING EFFECTS OF LIBERAL ARTS COLLEGE SHUTDOWNS

...S CLOSE

BY: **AUBRIE WILLIAMS**

In January 2023, high school senior Katherine Gaffney toured Cabrini University, a school in suburban Radnor, Pennsylvania. "You would have thought that it was a perfectly good school, and I loved it when I showed up. So I decided to go there," she explained. But less than six months later, in June 2023, Katherine received an email informing her that Cabrini would be shutting its doors the following year. The 2023-2024 school year would be its final operating year. "I actually thought it was a joke," Gaffney explained. "The fact that a college can close is not something that I ever thought could be possible."

Instead of a freshman year focused on orienting herself to a new campus, Gaffney's was spent scrambling to research transfer options. While Gaffney received support from Cabrini, she felt limited by the few "partner schools" that worked with Cabrini to accept students' credits. "Those schools kind of weren't meant for everybody," she explained. "I'm on the golf team. Not all of them had golf teams. I'm a Criminology major. Some of them didn't even have Criminal Justice, and none of them had Criminology." These limitations left Gaffney and many other students feeling like they had to fend for themselves when it came to determining their next steps. In fact, the closure ended up cutting off some students' educational journeys entirely. "I know there were quite a few freshmen who didn't end up going to school again," said Gaffney. "I think part of that is because there was such a lack of pushing...Nobody was pushing you to be better. Nobody was pushing you to continue. They'd almost sort of given up already because they knew they were closing."

Gaffney's story has become more and more common as a wave of closures sweeps through the country's small, private liberal-arts colleges. These closures are driven by several factors, including a shift in public perception about the value of higher education. Many Americans are questioning whether a traditional liberal arts education is worth the high cost.

A Gallup and Lumina Foundation report from 2024 indicated that nearly 1/3 of polled American adults possessed little or no confidence in higher education. Nearly 1/3 of those polled said that college was "too expensive," and 24% agreed that college students are not being taught what they need to succeed. This focus on return on investment drives students away from institutions that emphasize a broad liberal arts education and not specialized, career-focused training. This is reflected in recent cuts in liberal arts programs made by both private and public schools. Robert Kelchen, a professor of higher education at University of Tennessee at Knoxville, feels that these cuts are underreported in comparison to the more dramatic story of college closures. While the closure of liberal arts institutions merits attention, Kelchen feels that "the bigger issue is colleges having to make big cuts to stay open and avoid closures, but this gets a lot less attention."

Larry Schall, President at the New England Commission of Higher Education, discussed these changing sentiments about college, explaining, "A college education... has increasingly been considered a private [good]. College is a place to be prepared for the workforce." Applicants are increasingly selecting colleges based on their ability to give students a competitive edge.

This sentiment also helps explain the rise in interest in trade schools. A National Student Clearinghouse Research Center report indicates that from 2022 to 2023, enrollment in vocational-focused community colleges increased 16%. Much of this interest comes from an expectation that trade schools, which have lower costs and offer more immediate job prospects, provide better return on investment than

"THEY'D ALMOST SORT OF GIVEN UP ALREADY BECAUSE THEY KNEW THEY WERE CLOSING."

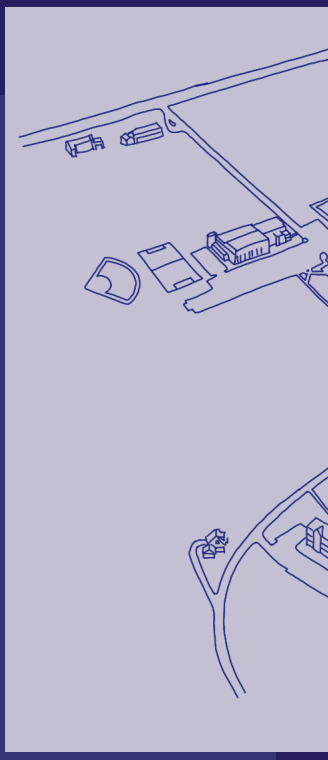
"I HEARD ONE KID THROUGH A PROFESSOR SAY, 'WELL, I GUESS I'LL GO BACK IN THE CLOSET.' THIS IS WHEN THEY WERE TRYING TO TRANSFER TO ANOTHER SCHOOL. THEY JUST REALLY DIDN'T HAVE VERY MANY OPTIONS."

liberal arts education.

Michael Horn, an adjunct lecturer at Harvard Graduate School of Education and the author of several books on education, adds that liberal arts schools also have declining appeal since they tend to be in more rural locations. "More and more students have wanted to go to college in urban environments, because that's where the jobs are," Horn said.

But one of the largest empirical factors contributing to college closures is simply a decline in enrollment, which is expected to worsen in the coming years. This is due to the approaching 'enrollment cliff'—a demographic shift that will result in fewer college-age students in the coming years due to declining birth rates following the 2008 recession. Nathan Grawe, an economist at Carleton College who coined the term, predicts that between 2025 and 2029, the population of students attending college will decrease by 15%. Small colleges are especially sensitive to enrollment fluctuations. "If you have a first year class of, say, 200 students, and you miss targets by 20 students. That's 10% of your first year budget potential," Horn explained.

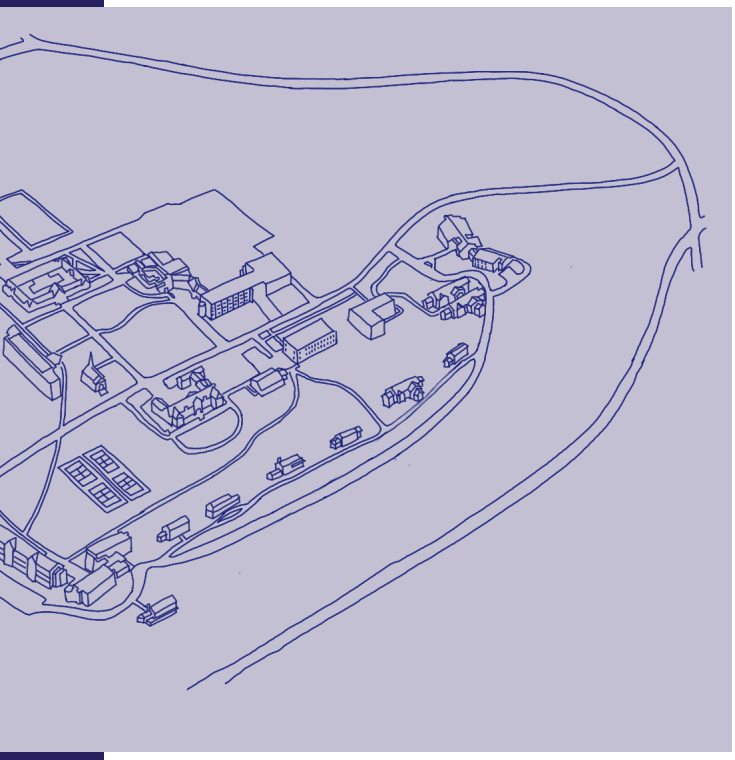
Colleges that have recently closed their doors, like Cabrini University, Cazenovia College, and Birmingham Southern College, all cited declining enrollment as a major factor. Cazenovia, which shut its doors at the end of June 2023, faced $25 million in debt partially caused by declining enrollment. Former president David Bergh specifically mentioned the aforementioned demographic shifts as the issue. "There are far fewer 18 and 22 year olds out there, and that's especially pronounced in the Northeast and the Midwest, where a ton of small, traditional, often rural, liberal arts colleges are," Bergh explained.



When colleges face these issues, the question of transparency immediately becomes important. Administration must tow a narrow line between providing students and faculty adequate notice before the closure while avoiding premature panic or hastening the college's decline. "On the one hand, you want to do everything you can as long as possible to keep the place alive," said Bergh. "There's no way that you can come out and announce that you're struggling and may not make it. By that very announcement, you have kind of made the determination."

Cazenovia only remained open for one semester after announcing its plans to close. Bergh and his colleagues dedicated that semester to helping students find transfer opportunities, despite the strange environment it brought to campus. Bergh explained, "We had college fairs on our campus in the spring, which was kind of an odd thing to be doing, to have other schools on your campus recruiting." Bergh's efforts were motivated by a striking reality: fewer than half of students transfer to other institutions when their college closes, leaving most students unable to complete their degrees. "Unfortunately, I've seen a lot of closures more recently in which the announcement ends up being made late in the spring or even over the summer, and it really takes away the ability of the institution to help its students."

College closures can be especially devastating for students in small, rural communities where the institutions long served as havens for marginalized identities. This was the case for Birmingham Southern College, which shut its doors this past spring.



sive institution known for its LGBTQ+ acceptance. Brooke Battle, a former trustee of the college, poignantly noted, "I heard one kid through a professor say, 'Well, I guess I'll go back in the closet.' This is when they were trying to transfer to another school. They just really didn't have very many options."

Birmingham Southern's closure also left consequences beyond the immediate school community. Brit Batlock, a Birmingham native who attended nearby Samford College, discussed the "brain drain" that occurs when communities lose these schools. "There's a massive economic loss... the loss of jobs, the loss of opportunity, the loss of an accessible college right there in people's hometown area," she said.

Often overlooked in discussions about college closures are the broader ramifications these events have on their surrounding communities. Larry Schall, director of The New England Commission of Higher Education explained, "Small colleges located in small towns have sort of forever been the sort of economic anchor of that town... I think it does really have a significant impact on the broader community. That's one thing that people don't talk about so much."

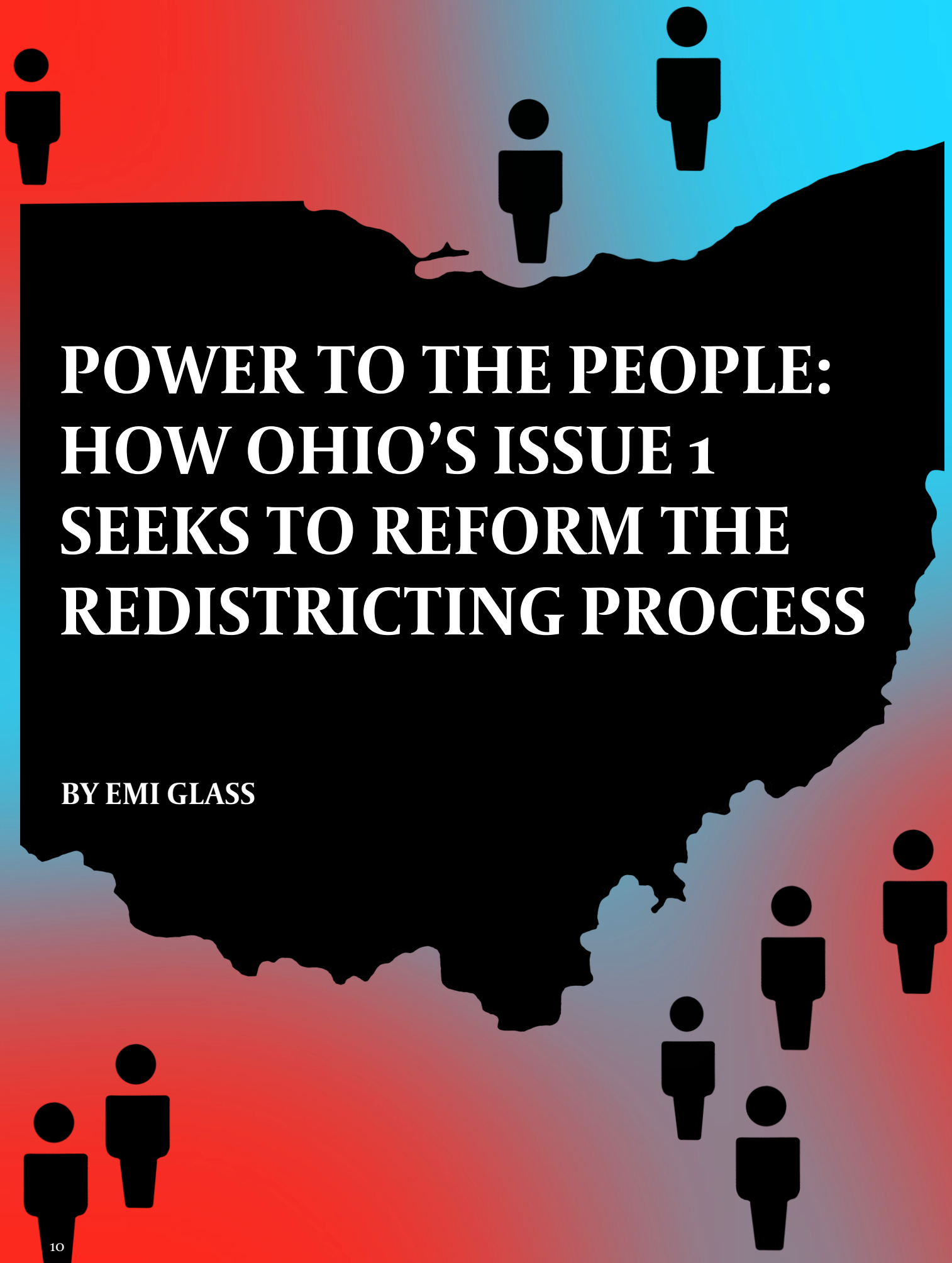
While economic considerations are important, college closures also have profound social impacts on the community. Battle commented, "My daughter who's in high school here...her favorite teacher at her high school moved because his wife was a professor at BSC and got a new job in California."

Batlock feels that BSC in particular drove the entire city of Birmingham to become a more accepting place. "Not only was it a good economic driver inside the city, but it also became a space where racial relations could be repaired and bettered over the years," Batlock said. She added that BSC offered a unique attraction for several intellectual thinkers that are now absent in the city, adding, "A lot of those professors probably chose BSC very carefully as the kind of institution they wanted to be at. And when you work in that world, you can't pop from college to college. When we lose entities that were specifically attracting people with educated backgrounds, it's to the loss of the whole state, not just the city itself."

As the world of higher education prepares for even steeper declines in enrollment, the stories of Cabrini, Cazenovia, and Birmingham Southern serve as stark reminders of what is lost when a college closes. Beyond just students and faculty, entire communities feel the absence of these colleges, which serve as economic anchors, gateways to education, and a source of identity for towns both large and small across the United States.

Gaffney is feeling that loss of community as she adjusts to her first year at nearby Arcadia University. "I definitely miss [Cabrini]," Gaffney said. "I have a piece of me that hates them because they closed, because I loved it so much." Gaffney lives in Illinois. Moving to Pennsylvania was a big shift for her. The community at Cabrini eased this transition. "At Cabrini, I never really felt that sense of homesickness," Gaffney said. "But after I came back to this new school...I realized that I was homesick, but I wasn't homesick for my home. I was homesick for Cabrini."

"BUT AFTER I CAME BACK TO THIS NEW SCHOOL...I REALIZED THAT I WAS HOMESICK, BUT I WASN'T HOMESICK FOR MY HOME. I WAS HOMESICK FOR CABRINI."



POWER TO THE PEOPLE: HOW OHIO'S ISSUE 1 SEEKS TO REFORM THE REDISTRICTING PROCESS

BY EMI GLASS



"This is a really profound challenge to democracy that we're witnessing in Ohio. It's a little bit like the end of a movie, a Star Wars moment here, where there's either going to be a little ray of hope for real, fair elections in Ohio. Or, if Issue 1 fails, it's just going to reaffirm that Ohio elections can be decided before the vote even starts," said David Niven, a professor of American Politics at the University of Cincinnati. Niven underscores what is at stake in November 2024 for Ohioians.

Issue 1, a ballot initiative being voted on by Ohioians in the 2024 election, would amend the Ohio Constitution to delegate the legislative redistricting power to citizens of the state, removing elected officials from the redistricting process. While much of the country is focused on what is sure to be a highly competitive presidential race, Niven emphasizes that the future of democracy itself is also on the ballot for the state of Ohio.

* * *

Issue 1 would establish a 15-member citizen commission composed of five independents and five members of each of the top two political parties, the Republicans and the Democrats. These members could not be elected officials, lobbyists, or political consultants. A screening panel composed of four retired judges would select citizens for the commission. Two of the judges would be Republicans and two would be Democrats. According to the proposed amendment, this screening panel would consider the commission applicants' "qualifications, conflicts of interest, party affiliation, relevant experiences and skills, community ties, and commitment to impartiality, compromise, and fairness."

"The bottom line is Issue 1 would take the line drawing power away from politicians and put it in [the hands] of real people. It would take what Ohio has now, which is a hyper-partisan line-drawing process, and create a system that's inherently balanced with regard to partisanship."

The proposed amendment would mitigate partisan gerrymandering—the redrawing of legislative districts in a manner that provides one political party an unearned advantage over another. Partisan gerrymandering results in districts that have illogical shapes, separating communities with shared social and economic interests and making for less-competitive elections. This issue is particularly salient in Ohio, which is considered one of the most gerrymandered states in the country.

"The bottom line is Issue 1 would take the line drawing power away from politicians and put it in [the hands] of real people. It would take what Ohio has now, which is a hyper-partisan line-drawing process, and create a system that's inherently balanced with regard to partisanship," Niven said. Issue 1 aims to replace the existing Ohio Redistricting Commission, the politician-led group that currently heads redistricting in the state. A 2018 ballot initiative established the Ohio Redistricting Commission with the goal of limiting partisan gerrymandering. This initial reform emphasized bipartisanship by requiring the Commission to include members from both the majority and minority party. The commission includes one member appointed by the Senate President, one member appointed by the Speaker of the House, one member appointed by the Senate Minority Leader, one member appointed by the House Minority Leader, the Governor, the Auditor, and the Secretary of State. Additionally, two Commission members aligned with the minority party must approve the electoral maps to ensure this bipartisanship.

In 2022, the Ohio Redistricting Commission failed several times to produce constitutional, non-gerrymandered maps. Minority party members did not support the Commission's new maps, which gave Republicans a disproportionate advantage in Ohio elections.







The matter of fairly-drawn districts is generally important to Ohioans of all backgrounds, regardless of age, occupation, or party affiliation. In past ballot measures, Ohioans have overwhelmingly voted to mitigate partisan gerrymandering and to create more fair legislative districts. In 2018, 74.89% of Ohioians voted in favor of the ballot initiative that established the Ohio Redistricting Commission. Still, many feel that these past measures have fallen short of providing an ethical redistricting system.

Ultimately, politicians produced maps just as gerrymandered as they had before the 2018 referendum was passed.

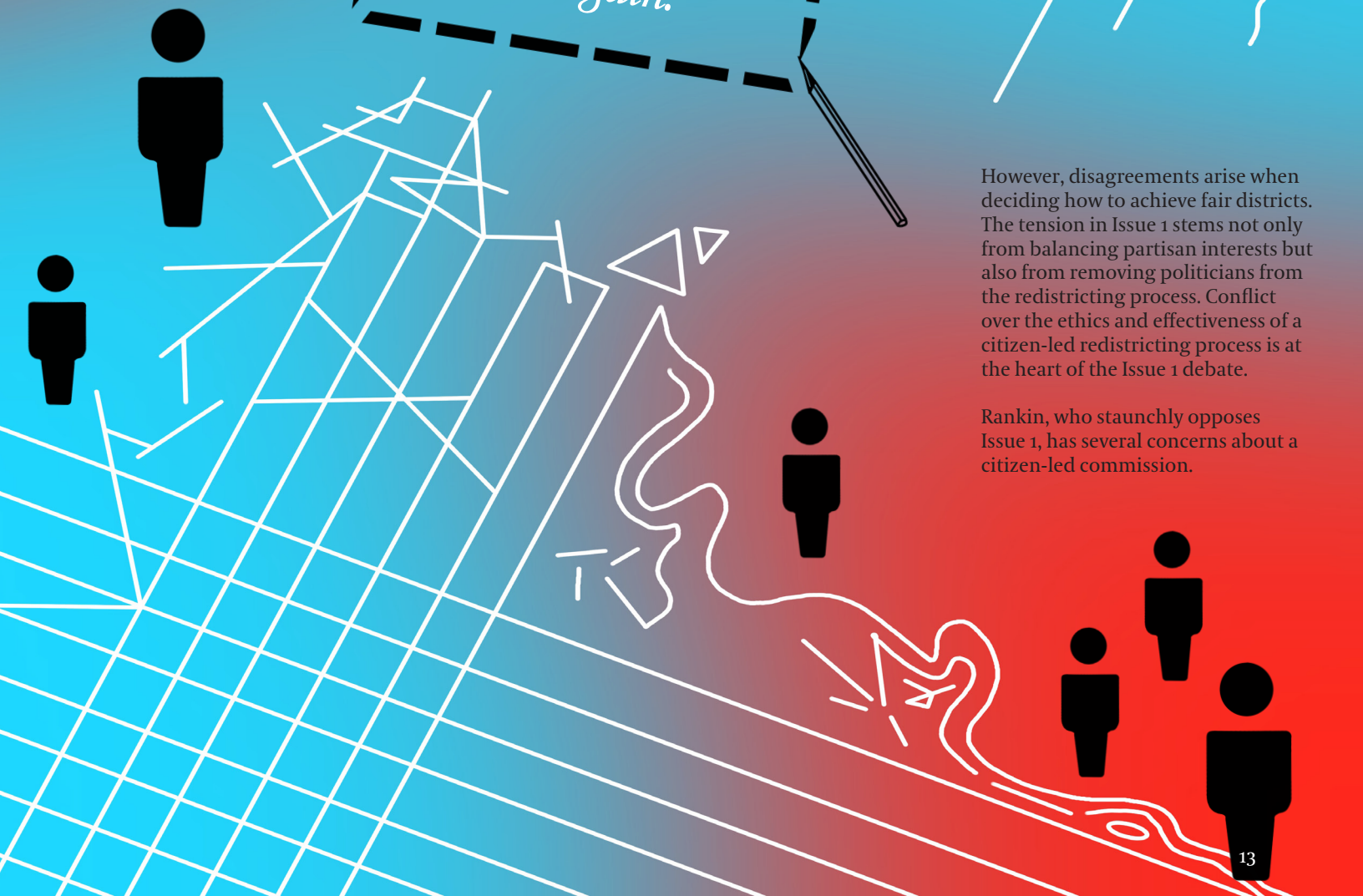
The Ohio Supreme Court deemed the Commission's maps as an unconstitutional partisan gerrymander, and no bipartisan compromises emerged. Partisan gerrymandering persists in spite of the establishment of this independent commission.

As a result, the state had no choice but to use outdated and unconstitutional Congressional maps. After the shortcomings of the 2018 reform, activist groups developed the amendment language seen in Issue 1 as a path of recourse.

Selma Younes, a junior studying Criminal Justice at the University of Cincinnati, said that Ohio redistricting is in need of additional reform: "We need a more ethical system when it comes to creating these districts, so that way we can make sure that we are exercising democracy in the best way that we can as a state."

Tim Rankin, chairman of central Ohio's Franklin County Republican Party, shares Younes's interest in promoting a fair redistricting process. Rankin said, "I think you want fair representation. You want districts to be drawn in a way that there [is] fair representation. Ethics are always a deep concern."

"Ohio's previous redistricting reform was well-intentioned, but it was a spectacular failure because it invested power in people who invested power in people who simply used the process for their own gain."



However, disagreements arise when deciding how to achieve fair districts. The tension in Issue 1 stems not only from balancing partisan interests but also from removing politicians from the redistricting process. Conflict over the ethics and effectiveness of a citizen-led redistricting process is at the heart of the Issue 1 debate.

Rankin, who staunchly opposes Issue 1, has several concerns about a citizen-led commission.

"These are going to be unelected, appointed surrogates of the politicians who [will] be given a green light if this were to pass. These folks who are going to be put on this commission are not going to be directly electable, directly answerable to the voting public. That's a huge issue," Rankin said.

Rankin is not the only Ohioan with concerns regarding accountability. Opponents of Issue 1 are wary of placing unelected individuals at the head of the redistricting process. They cite that, at least with the current system, if a member of the Ohio Redistricting Commission does something they view as unacceptable, the public can vote against them in the next election cycle.

The accountability argument is complicated. In theory, Ohioans can vote out representatives who they are unhappy with. However, in practice the current state of partisan gerrymandering is self-reinforcing. Ohio voters who align with the Democratic Party—and who reside in partisan gerrymandered districts—may feel as if they have no power to vote out their Republican representatives.

"This is one of those impressively circular arguments in which the opponents are saying, 'If you make this change, it will take away accountability.' The entire reason for this proposal in the first place is there's no accountability," Niven said. "So yes, in theory, the line drawers could be voted out of office, but they're drawing lines they can't be voted out of office from."

Some Ohio voters believe removing politicians from the redistricting process would promote democratic accountability. Younes said, "Overall, I'd want [the redistricting commission] to be citizen-led, because, you know, 'We the People.' It's not working currently, and right now, the politicians are picking their voters, rather than the other way around."

Cynthia Spargur, a retiree and Ohio voter, shared the same sentiment. Although she aligns with the Republican Party on most issues, in regards to redistricting, Spargur said, "You definitely don't want politicians in on that mix."



* * *

Another source of debate regarding this amendment involves the official ballot language the Ohio Ballot Board wrote. For some Ohio voters, the summary language appearing on their ballot on Election Day may be the only information they receive about Issue 1.

Citizens Not Politicians (CNP), the advocacy group that drafted and gathered over 700,000 signatures to put Issue 1 on the ballot, sued the Ohio Ballot Board for what they say is an unfair description of their proposed amendment.

CNP proposed the Issue 1 amendment in an attempt to lessen the impacts of partisan gerrymandering in Ohio. However, Section 2 of the ballot language states that the proposed amendment would, "establish a new taxpayer-funded commission of appointees required to gerrymander the boundaries of state legislative and congressional districts to favor either of the two largest political parties in the state of Ohio, according to a formula based on partisan outcomes as the dominant factor."

The idea that Issue 1 requires gerrymandering is sourced from the proportionality requirement of the proposed amendment. The actual language from the proposed amendment states that the new system aims, "to ban partisan gerrymandering and prohibit the use of redistricting plans that favor one political party and disfavor others," by requiring that "the statewide proportion of districts in each redistricting plan that favors each political party shall correspond closely to the statewide partisan preferences of the voters of Ohio."

In their summary of Issue 1, the Ohio Ballot Board characterizes gerrymandering as any redistricting that includes consideration of partisan affiliation. This would include Issue 1's proportional representation clause. CNP argued that the use of the term gerrymandering to describe this form of proportional representation is misleading for voters.

The Ohio Supreme Court granted CNP a partial victory in their case in September, ruling that certain sections of the ballot language must be revised. The court ordered rewording of sections related to the ability to challenge the new commission's decisions in court and the public's right to exert influence on the commission.

The most contentious part of the ballot language remains unchanged after the Ohio Supreme Court's ruling. The phrasing that the new amendment would create a commission "required to gerrymander" will remain in the official ballot language in this November 2024 election.

Proponents of Issue 1 find this characterization unfair and inaccurate.

"The ballot language chosen by the ballot board of Ohio refers to this amendment as requiring gerrymandering, and that is a rather extraordinary Orwellian proposition—that a ballot question to put regular people in charge of drawing fair districts requires gerrymandering," Niven said emphatically. "The way they got there is this convoluted assertion that if the districts should produce results that look something like the way people vote, that's gerrymandering, when in fact, that's the opposite of gerrymandering."

According to Niven, the Ohio Ballot Board attempted to redefine gerrymandering in the ballot language: "They made up a new meaning for gerrymandering. They made that meaning the opposite of gerrymandering, and they put it on the ballot for voters to see."

Beyond questions of accuracy regarding ballot language or definitions of technical terms like gerrymandering, Younes said the ballot language could confuse Ohio voters.

"I think that for a voter who is not super familiar with Issue 1 and gerrymandering, they may find those specific clauses as a little misleading or a little bit confusing," Younes said. "When I go in to vote, I know what I'm voting for, but some people don't know. They're not familiar with gerrymandering, and they go in to vote because they want to go vote for the presidential election. When they see

that there's other issues on the ballot that they maybe have not done enough research about, I think that that summary is extremely misleading."

Spargur echoes Younes; she recounted feeling confused herself when she first read the official ballot language.

"The words [are] tricky, and it's difficult to understand exactly what they're doing. I'm planning on voting yes, but the way the whole issue is worded, it sounds like you're voting yes to vote no," Spargur said.

The ballot language is dramatically different from both what is written in the proposed amendment and what would be added to the Ohio Constitution. How did the language change so drastically? And why did this change occur?

Niven has an answer.

"In theory, the ballot board is a nonpartisan entity. It's two Democrats, it's two Republicans—but the fifth member of the ballot board is the Secretary of State. So if you have a rabidly partisan Secretary of State, the ballot board goes from nonpartisan to hyperpartisan, and that's what happened here in Ohio," Niven said. "The Secretary of State is very openly campaigning against Issue 1 and wrote language to try to defeat Issue 1. All of this could have been settled and fixed by the Ohio Supreme Court, but it's also a Republican-controlled Ohio Supreme Court."

However, not everyone believes this language is incorrect, unfair, or misleading.

Rankin, for example, holds a complimentary stance towards the Ballot Board's characterization of Issue 1. Rankin credits Frank LaRose, the Ohio Secretary of State, for providing a fair summary of the issue. "I think the Secretary of State did a great job. I think he has proven himself since he's been the Secretary of State. That's something that he's always treated very fairly and evenly," he said.

* * *

The final question of Issue 1 regards the best recourse for eliminating partisan gerrymandering.

Rankin said people have been too quick to judge the current system. Despite its past issues, Rankin believes that, if given time, the Ohio Redistricting Commission as it stands can provide fair districts for Ohioians.

"I think the system as it's [currently] structured, from what I have seen in the alternatives, is the best system that's there. I think there is a perception that the folks involved with the Commission did not play well in the sandbox together, and it came off that it wasn't a properly functioning commission," Rankin said in regards to the shortcomings of the 2022 redistricting process.

Conversely, Niven does not believe the current Ohio Redistricting Commission could create the equitable districts that Rankin imagines.

Niven said, "Ohio's previous redistricting reform was well-intentioned, but it was a spectacular failure because it invested power in people who invested power in people who simply used the process for their own gain."

Other opponents of Issue 1 argue that it is redundant: Ohio voters have already taken a position on the issue of gerrymandering in the form of past amendments. The official ballot language characterizes the proposed amendment this way as well. The ballot language states that the proposed amendment would: "repeal constitutional protections against gerrymandering approved by nearly three-quarters of Ohio electors…in the statewide elections of 2015 and 2018."

While the language holds the same partisan twinge as the phrase "required to gerrymander," only Ohio voters can answer this question of redundancy at the polls.

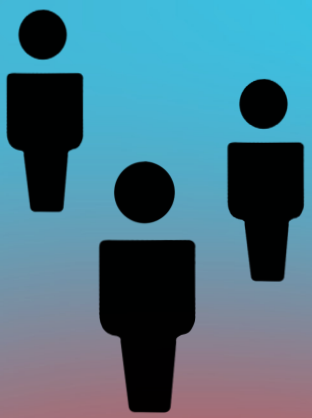
* * *

Niven predicts the vote on Issue 1 will be very close. He said the success of the amendment is contingent on Republicans not voting as a block.

"When you ask people, [should] regular people draw [districts], or politicians, they say regular people. It's just a question of how effective the Republican hysteria message [is]. If they can hold their Republican base together, it fails, but they have shown an inability to do that in recent ballot questions. They lost last year on reproductive rights. If people are thinking about fairness and real people drawing districts, Issue 1 can pass. In all likelihood, it's going to be close," said Niven.

Issue 1 aims to transition redistricting power from politicians to everyday citizens. In 2022, Ohioans voted in an election with maps that had repeatedly been declared unconstitutional.

In the upcoming November 2024 election, there is another chance for Ohio voters to decide who they want to draw their districts. Time will tell if this new reform can end partisan redistricting in one of the most gerrymandered states in the country.









NOT YOUR ENEMY

IN DEFENSE OF REPUBLICANS VOTING FOR TRUMP

AN OPINION PIECE

BY: ALEX MCDONALD



Photo Credit: Scott Olsen/Getty Images

The central argument against former President Donald Trump is that his populist appeal endangers the very foundation of our republic. In making this attack, Democrats have created a pendulum for democracy or dictatorship, framing Trump's voters as the underbelly of insurrection. The relentless vilification of his supporters may pose as grave a threat to our social fabric as a second Trump term would.

The overwhelming fear perpetuated by the media surrounding the upcoming election—that it is do or die, democracy or dictatorship—limits voters to a single acceptable option: the Democratic nominee. This disinterest in policy and focus on personality may cost Democrats the election. By branding Trump as America's Hitler, Democrats implicitly malign Republicans voting for Trump as facilitators of fascism, widening the chasm in a deeply fractured nation.

It is true that Trump has said and done bigoted things. His rhetoric often invites hate into the heart of the GOP, stoking an ongoing fire of division in American society. Through stereotyping and dog-whistling, Trump has welcomed and appeased groups like The Proud Boys to 'stand back and stand by.' He has even gone so far as to defend white supremacists. Trump referred to the white supremacists who incited violence at the 2017 Charlottesville Unite the White Rally as 'very fine people' caught in a conflict he described as a "many sides" issue—a disturbing description.

Trump's controversial remarks often fall deaf on the ears of conservatives who believe the media to be hypocritical and biased toward Democrats. Many Republicans cannot help but notice that many of the same figures and on-air personalities who once tolerated or embraced Trump's unvarnished persona began to criticize his character only after he ran as a Republican in the 2016 Presidential Election.

Take the established liberal ladies of The View, Joy Behar and Whoopi Goldberg, who both mingled with and cozied up to Donald Trump before he ran for President as a Republican. In 2003, while introducing him to The View's panel, Behar called him an "upstanding American," smiling while touching his hair. During a 2011 appearance on The View, where Trump falsely claimed President Barack Obama was not born in the United

States, Goldberg pushed back against Trump's rhetoric, but made sure to conclude the show on friendly terms with him, linking hands with Trump and saying, "we are friends." The late great Barbara Walters affirmed this claim of friendship, concluding the feisty 2011 segment by saying, "You [Donald] are a great friend of ours."

It seems that the media only expressed qualms with Trump's behavior after he announced his candidacy.

The blanket characterization of Trump's supporters as a cadre of bigoted stormtroopers is dead wrong. And it's tired.

Today, Goldberg boycotts Trump's name, referring to him as "you know who." She also admonishes supporters of Trump like Dr. Ben Carson. In a 2016 appearance on The View, Carson was lambasted by Goldberg, who said support like Carson's is "how Hitler got in." Behar, for her own part, says Trump's supporters "have issues," and that supporters wearing the red hat may as well "put a swastika on it." This is the same Behar who attended Trump's weddings and considered herself "pals" with the billionaire real estate developer just a year before he announced his presidential run.

Behar and Goldberg are just two examples of the many media personalities who were once indifferent to Trump's controversies but were suddenly enraged by his public character after he ran as a Republican. For decades, elitist circles tolerated much of Trump's behavior that is currently condemned, including his role in the racially charged 1989 Central Park Five case, the Nixon DOJ's lawsuit against his company for refusing to rent to Black tenants, and various allegations of discriminatory business practices throughout the '90s and '00s.

Trump's base watched a 'Celebrity Trump' who was beloved and befriended by the likes of Behar and Goldberg for years. But once he rode down the escalator as a Republican, with a call to represent 'forgotten about' Americans, his unsavory past behavior was called into question, and he was then smeared as a racist and a bigot.

The Donald Trump that Hillary Clinton now condemns as "allied with white supremacists and neonazis, with unrepentant racists, and misogynists," is the same Donald Trump she smiled up at, arm in arm, during his wedding to Former First Lady Melania Trump in 2005.

***

The Trump base in 2024 is largely torn between Trump's ego and his America First agenda, which includes policies they strongly resonate with. Issues related to the economy, crime, and national security—such as lowering taxes and rolling back regulation, harsher sentencing for violent crime, a stronger border, and less reliance on foreign energy—drive his base to vote and to back MAGA.

As Michael Gold of the New York Times recently reported, what "resonates more with his audiences" is the bread and butter issues of traditional politics—issues that affect everyday Americans—not the prospect of a Trump dictatorship.

The mainstream media often stretches the truth and fixates on doomsday-ish depictions of Trump as the first American dictator, backed by a depraved base. The popularized Trumpocalyptic world is eye-grabbing and sensational, but the news stories about it aren't usually newsworthy. Headlines like CNN's "'Revenge' & 'Dictatorship'" or The Forward's "1932 was a pivotal year in the Nazis' ascent, a terrifying parallel for today"—published two days after an attempt on Trump's life and just a day after he thanked President Biden for his call to unity—fail to spark meaningful dialogue in a nation where political tensions are dangerously close to boiling over. Detached from reality, this kind of rhetoric displays the glaring disconnect between the mainstream media and the issues that concern many Republican voters.

When Trump's voters hear him speak, they hear the good, groan at the bad, and they move on. I hear this all the time: "Well I wish he'd just stop ranting," "if he could just stop tweeting," "...but his policies." Trump's supporters learn to look past

the name-calling and ramblings, finding refuge in Trump's America First policies that will advance opportunities for a working class American Dream. For over eight years, Trump's base has faced relentless attack and vilification, as Democrats and the mainstream media unfairly and zealously attribute Trump's flaws to his supporters.

Proponents of the mantra 'Make America Great Again' (MAGA) do not seek the restoration of Jim Crow, as pundits have insisted for a decade now, and Trump voters are not Klansmen seeking the revival of a racial contract. Trump voters are Americans; rich and poor, Black and white, gay and straight, evangelical and atheist, and all in between who see a fragment in the MAGA movement they connect with and relate to. The media seldom recognizes that Trump's supporters are, more often than not, down-to-earth, empathetic, and intelligent contributors to society who span many walks of life. They are not monolithic in their views of Trump or the world. The blanket characterization of Trump's supporters as a cadre of bigoted stormtroopers is dead wrong. And it's tired.

When Democrats assert that Trump's entire agenda risks awakening a sleeping giant of racism in America, they overlook the reasons many Republicans continue to support him despite incidences of fear-mongering and bigotry. A large portion of Trump's base is people struggling to put food on their tables and find stable employment in a changing economy. A base that sees prices up 20% under the Biden-Harris administration and the highest inflation rate in 40 years is a base willing to accept another four years of Trump. Because, in the Trump era, gas prices were down 21%, groceries were three-fourths of what they cost now, and 401(k)s were up nearly 50%. Additionally, despite the provocation of world leaders, there were no wars under the Trump administration. While Republicans may find his guttered mouth annoying, they look to Trump's deliverables.

In an era of a dying middle class, a period in which small business is flooded in red tape and in which soaring inflation makes the poor poorer and the rich richer, MAGA symbolizes a cry for stability. Democratic hypocrisy, seen in ambitious climate policies that change the working lives of millions while elites peruse the world in their private jets, spits in the face of the worker trying to survive in a modernizing economy.

Pressuring voters to set aside policy differences in light of a perceived threat to democracy obscures the ongoing struggles faced every day by countless Americans. Telling voters to prioritize character over policy is tone-deaf and assumes they share the same privilege as political pundits who can afford to ride out the storm of rising inflation.

MSNBC's Chris Hayes dedicated an hour to the imminent demise of American democracy, drawing an overblown connection to Trump and Project 2025, which Trump has repeatedly denounced. Meanwhile, a family of four is hurting: they are paying an additional $1,261 per month to survive under the Biden-Harris administration.



The Democratic Party's lofty theories and ambitions remain out of touch with the realities of Americans struggling to make ends meet.

Describing Trump's supporters as fascist sheep is cheap. They, most of whom reside in middle America—in suburbs and rural communities—are ostracized by Democrats, who grandstand from a mountaintop of cultural elitism. So, when Trump's supporters seek to "drain the swamp" and gut "the Deep State," it is not an elaborate conspiracy to give Trump dictatorial authority or eliminate a professional civil service. The deep state, as they understand it, reflects the exclusive, closed-door room in which Hillary Clinton made her 'basket of deplorables' comment—a glitzy high-end donor event in New York attended by members of an elite class who mock regular Americans for their supposed ineptitude, foolishness, and bigotry. The deep state, to Trump's supporters, is a room to democracy they do not have access to, where kingpins make unilateral decisions away from transparency and accountability.

To assume Trump's supporters are reckless and malevolent is lazy. It is also dangerous. This mindset mires the Democratic Party in a culture of elitism, which will cost them until they wake up from their self-aggrandizing slumber. Trump's supporters are collateral for the Clintons and establishment politicians, those who resent Trump for his ability to resonate with everyday Americans.

The "forgotten men and women of our country," as Trump calls his base, are largely an obscure crowd—at least in the eyes of those who call the Hamptons their summer home, or for pundits who insist that voters place "character" over issues like the cost of living. Outside of elite and academic circles, Trump's voters are family, friends, neighbors, oh, and half the country.

For every decry of Trumpist existentialism, another working-class American squirms in their living room, numb to the empty rhetoric and eager for lower gas and grocery prices. Rather than hearing that Trump's existence poses a grave threat to freedom and "everything America stands for," regular Americans (not the contemporary X philosopher) crave tangible results over hyperbole. The great disillusionment plaguing the Democratic Party sums half of the country as freedom-fighters and labels the other half as insurrectionists.

Though I hold serious concerns regarding Trump, I understand why millions do not share my concerns. In a digital era programmed to divide, where we all live in our own siloed echo chambers shaped by targeted algorithms, we universally approach politics at an uphill climb.

We take shortcuts that drive us down rabbit holes, and because no one is immune to misinformation, we should be graceful to those we disagree with.

I trust the conclusions drawn up about

For every decry of Tru existentialism, another working-cl American squirms in living room, numb t empty rhetoric and e for lower gas and grocery prices.

mpist

ass
their
o the
ager
l

politics, on Trump or Harris, will be drawn by people who care about the future of our country—because we all hold an equal stake in that future.

I trust Trump's supporters when they exercise their First Amendment rights, because those are the people who raised me in my small hometown of Willows, California; people who feed, support, educate, and tend to their communities; kind, thoughtful, innovative, and forgiving Americans, who uplift their towns in the face of despair and come together in shared celebration.

I'm empowered by the people back home, who see my position as a small-town boy at Yale as an opportunity to bring awareness to the humanity of rural America, people who feel forgotten by Washington. Their support of Trump is as much a rejection of establishment politicians who alienate them as it is an endorsement of him.

Disdain and apathy for Trump's supporters rejuvenated the Make America Great Again movement and is paving the way for the populist ticket in 2024. The Trump appeal has spread to growing numbers of Latinos, African Americans, and even young people, who soured from a comatose Biden-Harris administration.

The rebirth comes in light of Democratic messaging that draws on theory, rather than reality.

The American people are lost in theatrical talk about Trump. To begin healing our nation's divide—a divide perpetuated by both sides to which Trump himself certainly contributes—Democrats must win with outcomes, not fan the flame of disorder by portraying Trump's supporters as modern-day confederates or American Nazis.

With a new nominee, Democrats have an opportunity to unify an exhausted and polarized nation. For the sake of their election prospects and for the health of our tethered republic, Democrats must make a case to Trump's supporters, not alienate them.



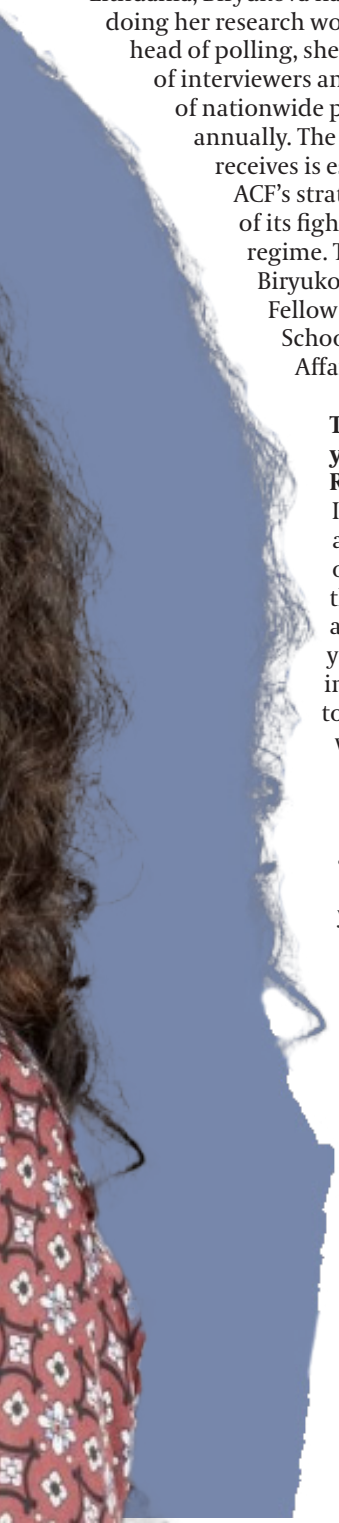
Photo Credit: Brian Snyder/REUTERS

Polling as Extremism:

A conversation with Anna Biriyukova on Putin's Regime and Modern Russia



By: Yegor Rubanov



Anna Biryukova is Head of Public Opinion Research at the Anti-Corruption Foundation (ACF), Russia's most significant opposition organization, founded by Alexey Navalny in 2011. Anna joined the team of the Russian opposition leader in 2013 during Navalny's election campaign for Mayor of Moscow. Since then, Biryukova has run independent and unbiased surveys, nationwide polls, and focus groups, always under immense pressure from Putin's regime. In 2019, she was forced to leave her country. Russian authorities considered her work—political polling—to be a terrorist and extremist activity. Living in exile in Lithuania, Biryukova has never stopped doing her research work. As ACF's head of polling, she manages a team of interviewers and runs dozens of nationwide polls in Russia annually. The reliable data she receives is essential to the ACF's strategic planning of its fight against Putin's regime. This semester, Biryukova is a World Fellow at the Jackson School of Global Affairs.

Tell me about your early life in Russia.
In Russia, there are certain types of small towns that are closed. In a town like this, you cannot get inside. You have to have a special, written paper that says you are okay to go inside. It's not a prison, it's a normal city. But you cannot visit unless you have permission. I was born in that type of town in Siberia. It was weird and fascinating at the same time because it was relatively safe. After my elementary school, I moved to a bigger town between Moscow and St Petersburg. My biggest dream back then was to study in Moscow.

What was your first perception of Vladimir Putin?
I'm 33, and Putin has been in power for 24 years. My first political memory is Putin. Compared to Yeltsin—old, drinking problems, weird—I was like, wow, that's my president. I'm sorry, but that was the truth back then.

All students in Russia got their education about the world by watching American movies. That's one hundred percent true, and the one thing I understood about life was that you have to be extremely patriotic about your country. I watched American students pledging to their flag, and I was like, wow, okay my country is a different one, but I also have a flag and I have a president, and I have to be that committed. Luckily, this delusion did not last long, but I think that at age 12 or something, I used to have a couple of notebooks with Putin's picture on them. Can you imagine? I was like that is my president. I have to be committed. Luckily, a little bit later, I educated myself. Now, I hate him so much. He is destroying Ukraine physically but at the same time, he is destroying the future of his very own country.

How did you manage to get past your unquestioning, patriotic perception of Putin?
There was a huge internet platform, LiveJournal, and I read a lot. I got my internet connection, and that was the window to the world for me. I remember one particular post when something really clicked. Putin used to like bragging a lot. On Google, you can find a picture of Putin scuba diving into the Black Sea. When he emerged on shore, he had in his hands two ancient vases. I guess that the vases were originally from some museum or something, but they staged the whole thing. I saw this, and I could not be fooled that much. I was young, but I could understand that this was staged. I think that was the first time I understood that this is all fake.

What was the general sentiment around you at the time? Your peers, how did they feel about him?
They were trying not to be involved. It was not for the younger generation. If you want to be a fashionable guy, you should care about your money and your future, not about being a part of society, not about the future of the country. This is why Alexei Navalny was very popular later. He made politics and activism the "new black."

When you see your president taking nice pictures for the older audience because he wants women of age to admire him, you want to be as far from that thing as possible. It's just weird. I don't want to be involved. I don't want to vote. I don't want to think about politics in this country, please. I want to stay back. It is such a convenient thing for each and every dictator. It's like we have an unwritten contract between the dictator and society: stay away, don't be involved, be inactive. Live your life. We don't interfere, you don't interfere.

Politics is a dirty business. They used to say if you don't want to get dirty, stay away. The most important thing is that the Russian political leaders are really weird. Think of many, many Trumps—not a single one, but lots of them—talking nonsense on state TV. You don't want to watch TV shows because of this. This is just, what's the word, cringe?

Do you think that at any point disengagement within Russian society turned into a regime of fear?
It began in 2014 when the war started. Unfortunately, the whole world did not perceive it as such. Back then, I took part in a huge street rally. Back then, it was possible. After the Crimea annexation, I held a sign with something like, "Crimea is Ukraine." Nothing happened to me. I was not arrested. I didn't get a fine. It happened step by step.

Now, if you post something, even if you are no one, click, that's it, you're in prison. Even if you repost something, even if it is not your own words, you are an easy target. You cannot be in a prisoner swap because no one knows you. They say that there are more than 1,000 political prisoners now. One hundred percent, there are many more than this number. No one knows them. Russia is a very big country.

What happened in 2019 for you to be put on the terrorist and extremist list?
I was put on the extremist list as a part of the ACF organization. I'm a terrorist because I was a part of one YouTube show talking about my work, and I said one sentence, "If you feel like setting fire to offices where they ask people to go to war, you should do it."

Do you think Putin had some sort of switch? There were a lot of rumors when the war was starting that he had some sort of COVID meltdown.

He reads only folders created for him. and he believes that these folders are reality. So here on this laptop, it's all fake news, but he believes his information is one hundred percent concrete. Just think about it. Day by day, your reality gradually differs from the real reality. It happened to him not because he was reading fake news on Twitter. He literally made it himself. And can you imagine, he has a whole whole room of Putin Pleasers. And they are like, what should I put in this new briefing for him? Should I upset him or not? Oh, no, of course not! I don't want to upset him. It also happens with polls. Upsetting polls and upsetting numbers should not be in folders. That's why there is no point in polling in general.

Within the Anti-corruption Foundation, we have two schools of thought. My school says that he's just crazy. He wants to be a savior. It is a religious thing for him. He wanted to be in history. The other school is for a practical approach: he wants to steal even more. He wants to be in power. That's why he needed this war.

Photo by: Evgeny Feldman



What was it like working for Navalny during his Moscow mayoral campaign?
In 2013, Alexei was fighting against Sergei Sobyanin, the current mayor. Sobiyanin was so ambitious and so bold that he was like, "Okay, I want to fight Navalny and show everyone that he's nothing, that he doesn't have support." A real fight like this had never happened before.

Everyone was interested in having some poll numbers and some data. I remember one particular research agency published Navalny's approval rating at 2.5%. That was true at the time, but he worked so hard that, in two months, he was at 28%.

All the agencies that did a lot of polls tried to downgrade him. They said his approval rating was 5-7%. Our own in-house polls predicted his approval rating reached 27.5% The outcome, spoiler alert, was that Sobiyanin got 51% and Alexei got 27.5%. That is not 2.5%. They actually had to fake results a little just for him [Sobianyin] to get more than 50%.



Did Navalny know he would be arrested in 2021?
That was one of the options. It is very important to understand that it happened before the full-scale invasion, and we definitely underestimated Putin back then. Did we understand that he would be capable of what he did later? No. We had this idea that it was too much for Putin to kill him in public, openly. After the full-scale invasion, after bombing cities and towns and villages, after what happened in Mariupol, come on. There were no red lines. Nothing was too much.

What was the response in Russia to the annexation of Crimea and Donbas and the revolution in Kyiv?
All the coverage was full of negativity. I was following it on the internet, of course. I think that, from that time, they started forming an alternative reality. This was the beginning of the end for the country.

The particular timing of the annexation was because of his low approval rating. We measured it every month, and it literally skyrocketed. It was fantastic, like plus 20% in one week.

The first time he ever said Navalny was six months ago after he was murdered. That is why I said it was like religious fear, "He who must not be named."

Do his approvals always skyrocket after a war or annexation?
He was trying to repeat the skyrocketing with Syria, but in Syria, it was a total disaster. He could not sell the idea of why we should do it. This country was so, so far away. I'm not sure that an average Russian could explain where this country is geographically. That narrative was not easy. We have so many problems within the country. Why should we spend our money there? They did not have a decent answer to that.

Many Ukrainians have a negative view of Navalny, especially in light of some of his comments regarding Crimea and the Russian-Ukrainian "brotherhood". What are your thoughts on this?
I knew him very closely. He was the most reasonable man and politician. Even in prison, he spoke. He was vocal about the war and I value it so much. There is a fantastic note he smuggled from prison, fifteen statements for Russia. It is on his website.



It is mostly about the war and the consequences of it, and Russia being accountable. I believe everyone should read it just because there is pretty much no room to debate on it. Every reasonable Russian citizen and every reasonable Ukrainian citizen should agree on these fifteen statements because they are wise, they are reasonable, and they are doable.

Does the lack of consequences Putin faces originate from the lack of punishment for the crimes of Soviet leadership?
After Crimea, Putin had no consequences. It actually started back in the Soviet Union, all Soviet nomenklatura had no consequences; they worked as a party elite back then.

As a student aged 12 or 13, I read my history books about Stalin. Only one paragraph about the Gulag, that's it. Ten paragraphs about Russia's great economy. This is how I was shaped. Later, I understood that, actually, there is a common narrative to compare Stalin and Hitler. If you are a Russian student, you have no idea about this. It's just not in the Russian school curriculum.

Now, in modern Russia, they've become politicians with no consequences, no self-reflection process, nothing.

Do you think, after Navalny's death, there will be anyone who can replace him? Or is that now impossible until Putin's gone?
We have Julia Navalnaya.

She's strong, she is amazing, she's powerful, she's educated. She's very, very smart, and oh my god, she's motivated. She's motivated a lot. She works very hard now, and I believe in her as a leader. One hundred percent, she has all my support.

What is your outlook on the future of Russia?
Russia is a mess now. Our journey to a decent future is so vague, so challenging, and so complicated. I have so many insecurities, and I feel so unsafe about the whole journey of each and every Russian, especially those who are fooled by Putin's propaganda. It would be a very painful process for them to understand all the consequences. I cannot imagine how painful it would be, but it should be, and it must be. And after that…after that, that would be a start.



Navigating Tradition and Transition:

Exploring Food Trucks at the New Haven Long Wharf



The first thing I noticed as I walked along New Haven's Long Wharf was a palpable sense of division. On one side of the sidewalk was a series of vibrant food trucks, whose dazzling colors, neon signs, and vibrant flags beckoned customers to try their delights. On the other side, the sea: a frosted mass of blue, each wave crashing onto the shore with a thunderous clap.

It was a cloudy day, and the sounds of screeching seagulls against the roar of the wind harmonized with the high-pitched yells of the food truck employees.

"Tacos, esquites, enchiladas! Come and get your quesadillas!"

Each truck displayed a wide array of food choices, from churros to tacos al pastor. I tried to resist temptation.

I had come to interview different vendors about the food truck community, New Haven's involvement in the Long Wharf, and the external challenges vendors were facing. What I discovered instead was polarization. Vendors disagreed about government intervention, the existence of a street-vendor community, and the futures of their businesses.

Edwin Sweeney, 86, is the co-owner of Sweeney Hot Dog King. I stumbled upon him accidentally, not initially registering his unassuming truck, which was almost camouflaged against the overcast sky. He was sitting on a stool alone in a dark corner of the interior. I had to lean into the small opening to ask him questions.

> "We've been here 64 years down Long Wharf, selling hot dogs. We were the first food truck down here."

"We've been here 64 years down Long Wharf, selling hot dogs. We were the first food truck down here…."

Sweeney explained that the food truck landscape started to change rapidly with the rise of Latin businesses in the area.

According to DataHaven, there has been a 15% increase in New Haven's total immigrant population from 2010 to 2020.

Sweeney also highlighted a citywide rise in prices—everything from insurance to rent. He described this economic shift as "a little tough."

"A lot of businesses can't afford the overheads. The food, the supplies, and the rent are expensive."

The unstable financial situation has exacerbated Sweeney's relationships with other vendors. When asked if there was a sense of "community" within the Long Wharf, Sweeney stated, "Well, we do talk to each other, but you got to take care of your own."

This isolationist approach is not necessarily shared by the other businesses in the Long Wharf.

Adrian Rodriguez, the owner of the food truck Old Mexico, stated, "There's always a community, almost like a camaraderie, a friendship. Everybody helps each other out." He explained that he frequently borrows gloves, utensils, napkins, and other supplies from his neighbor vendor, and has also lent out his own.

Jose Santana from the Puerto Rican food truck El Conquistador agreed, saying that the other food trucks offer assistance if any technical issues arise, including machinery failures, broken stoves, and forgotten supplies.

> "Well, we do talk to each other, but you got to take care of your own."

Although the idea of being in a "community" is not embraced by all parties, it does reflect broader issues at play. Sweeney's social separation from the Latin vendors—who make up the majority of the businesses on Long Wharf—reflects broader divisions in New Haven.

Sweeney's food truck is the only white-owned business in an industry dominated by immigrant vendors. It is also the only food truck serving American cuisine amid a sea of trucks specializing in food from across Latin America.

Sweeney links the rising prices to immigration as a whole.

"Well, let's face it, they [immigrants] are in the United States. They've got to work…They're looking to make it all in one week, one month, or one year…. Food business used to be the best business. No







"There's always a community, almost like a camaraderie, a friendship. Everybody helps each other out."



body bothered. The city used to help you. Now it's all got to have a one-dollar bill in front of it or something," he said.

The Latine community comprises 31% of New Haven's population. The dominance of Latin food trucks seems to be a natural byproduct of the city's changing demographics.

Marianella Gimenez, the cashier of the Mexican food truck La Patrona, commented on this new sense of reality, stating that customers in Long Wharf are overwhelmingly Latine, which explains the increased demand for Latin American food.

Is Sweeney simply failing to adapt to changing consumer tastes? Or, is Latin street food the future of the food truck industry? If the latter is true, Sweeney—representative of an unchanging, "traditional" street food culture—may find it challenging to exist within New Haven's evolving cultural reality.

Other fissures exist within the New Haven food truck industry. Vendors are divided both on the role that government assistance and regulation should play in their industry and on the efficacy of existing government programs aimed at assisting their community. Maria Corona, the owner of La Chalupa—a Mexican food truck first opened in 2016—spoke positively about government grants aimed at assisting small businesses.

Other vendors were not as positive.

Sweeney commented, "The city ain't helping us. It's just too expensive. Before, this was all free property for us to use. We used to pay real cheap for our licenses, but now everybody's after the money."

Rodriguez, owner of Old Mexico, expressed frustration with the new operating hours.

"[The Long Wharf] is shutting down at seven-thirty… it used to be shutting down at nine, and that really hurt our pockets a lot, because everybody comes out at night and now we have to shut down at seven."

El Conquistador's owner Santana complained about the overall state of the Long Wharf. He hopes the government will remodel and clean the streets, which will "give it more life."

One common theme touched on by a wide swath of Long Wharf's street vendors is the difficulty that comes with seasonal changes. In general, summer is the season that sees the most profit. As the weather becomes colder, consumption of street food declines. Giminez said that vendors' main priority during the winter is to "survive."

"You just have to keep going," Corona of La Chalupa declared.

> "We used to pay real cheap for our licenses, but now everybody's after the money."

While winter is a predictable challenge that vendors can plan for in advance, the COVID-19 pandemic caught Long Wharf's vendors unprepared.

"[The pandemic] put me out of business for two months at least, and I was going to stir crazy because I'm a workaholic. My wife threw me out of the house a couple of times…Let's face it, people had to stay home, no income. Life itself now ain't like it was 30 or 40 years ago," Sweeney noted.

Although the majority of the food trucks I encountered were relatively new—some only a few months old—those that survived the pandemic continue to feel its lingering effects.

La Chalupa, which started in 2016 and endured the pandemic, has continued to take hits. The owner, Corona, stated, "This year…what can I tell you, sales weren't like they were in 2019. There was a significant change. People were scared. This [past] summer, there wasn't much activity. We didn't get the sales we expected. It didn't happen."

The food truck industry is precarious. Margins are narrow and competition is fierce. From drops in sales from seasonal changes to the sustained impact of the pandemic, food truck owners are in a never-ending struggle to keep their businesses afloat.

Although newer businesses like El Conquistador claim to be "doing well," veterans have a more jaded view of what is to come. When asked if he was optimistic about the future, Sweeney had a clear answer: "Not really."







YARD WARS

Woodbridge's Campaign Sign Showdown

BY: Rory Schoenberger











Camera in hand, I hopped down from the car. As I focused the lens to catch the array of flags and campaign signs, I noticed something out of the corner of my eye. A neighborhood woman stood near my car, hastily scribbling something on a notepad. It's not until later, as she trails my car around twists and turns, that I realize she was writing down my license plate number. I never found out exactly why I was followed, but one thing was evident—parts of Connecticut are brimming with paranoia and hostility approaching this election season.

Walking through Yale's campus, the absence of campaign signs is stark. Yale has declared that "no campaign-related materials may be displayed externally on a university facility or in any university office or work space," but even the larger New Haven area hardly bears any flags. People may be less willing to advertise their beliefs; perhaps within a small community such as Yale, the potential of ostracizing others with strong political markers is too high.

As I drove the twenty minutes to Woodbridge, I only spotted the occasional American flag. Upon arrival, it was a different story. Flags and campaign signs from both sides of the political spectrum were plentiful. Signage spanned from traditional campaign signs to flags professing support for the Blue Lives Matter Movement or declaring that "Hate has no home here." Interestingly, individual neighborhoods in Woodbridge seem to be either brimming with flags and campaign markers, or completely void of them. I find it eerie passing from street to street, seeing either uniformly empty lawns or full-blown neighborhood political expression. This arrangement raises the question of what drives people to put up these markers of political identity—do people only display signs to disagree with their neighbors? Or do politically conscious residents just tend to choose the same neighborhoods to live in?

Democrats seemed to have mostly Harris-Walz signs on their yards, whereas the Republican houses I saw had an array of flags: not just Trump flags but also Blue Lives Matter, Red Lives Matter, and American flags. This observation questions the idea of patriotism—when I see an American flag on a house, I associate it with Republicans—does this suggest that patriotism leans Republican? As I drive through neighborhoods of flag-lined drives, I reflect that in recent years Republicans have grown towards nationalist, American-based signage, whereas Democrats have distanced themselves, perhaps not wanting to associate with what they believe to be a complicated history.

Yard signs are often described as an effective tool for increasing political candidates' chances, although study results are mixed. Green et. al. suggests that these signs can provide name exposure and viability (by demonstrating that the candidate's campaign has the resources to create and distribute signs) as well as indicating partisan affiliation. Perhaps Woodbridge residents are deploying yard signage to help their favored candidates; it may foster a greater sense of civic efficacy by giving them something to do beyond voting.

This line of thought brings me back to the question of what drives people to put up political signage. Another possibility is to signal one's political identity or assert allegiances in a hyper-local political faceoff. Republicans are the minority in Woodbridge and in Connecticut as a whole, yet I counted more conservative signs and flags than I did Democratic ones. Perhaps Republicans are hoping to exhibit their political identity in order to normalize their political affiliation and show others that it is acceptable to vote in accordance, or perhaps it's a case of neighborly competition. There's no telling which signs were placed first, but maybe the Democrat signage I saw was intended to counter the Republican ones, or vice versa.

Maybe this idea could help to account for the stark lack of flags in New Haven—perhaps the large Democratic majority subsumes the need for signage.



This arrangement raises the question of what drives people to put up these markers of political identity—do people only display signs to disagree with their neighbors? Or do politically conscious residents just tend to choose the same neighborhoods to live in?


020